This semester as a UNIV 101 Peer Leader has been one of the most meaningful experiences I've had in college so far. When I first started, I didn't know exactly what to expect, but I knew I wanted to help students feel supported and make their transition to college a little easier. My main job was to keep class discussions going, share my own college experiences, and encourage students to open up and connect with one another. I also helped lead small group activities, asked follow-up questions, and helped cover important topics like academic advising, study skills, time management, and procrastination. These are all things I've had to work on myself, so being able to talk about them honestly helped me connect with my students.

One of the most important things I learned about myself this semester is that I lead best through empathy and relatability. Being a first-generation student has shaped how I interact with others, especially students who feel overwhelmed or unsure of where they belong. In U101, I found myself naturally drawn to supporting those students who reminded me of my own first semester. I realized that my ability to share my personal struggles, including navigating school, work, and my research responsibilities, made students more comfortable seeking help. Mentoring individual students outside the classroom helped reinforce this strength. I learned that I am good at making students feel seen and understood, and that this creates trust, which is the foundation of meaningful guidance.

At first, I was nervous and a little shy. I've always been more on the introverted side, so speaking up and taking a leadership role didn't come naturally to me. But over time, I learned that leadership doesn't always mean being the loudest person in the room.

Sometimes it means being the one who listens, understands, and helps others find their own voice. I started stepping up more in class, checking in with students, and helping guide discussions when things got quiet. Each week I felt more confident and started to see how much my presence and effort mattered.

Working with my co-instructor has also taught me a lot about communication and responsibility. We have to plan lessons together, talk about what's working or not, and make sure we're on the same page for each class. It's helped me understand the importance of being dependable, organized, and proactive. There's a balance between waiting for direction and taking initiative, and I think I'm learning that balance better now.

Through this experience, I've also learned a lot about myself as a leader. Looking back on my Clifton Strengths results, I can see how they show up in my work as a Peer Leader. I like being flexible and going with the flow, especially when things don't go as planned. My empathy helps me connect with students and understand what they're going through, even when they don't say much. I've also realized how much I enjoy encouraging people and seeing them grow. These strengths fit perfectly with my leadership style, which according to Myers-Briggs is Introverted, Intuitive, Feeling, and Prospecting. It explains why I like helping from behind the scenes, focusing on relationships, and creating a positive environment rather than taking full control.

But I've also learned a lot about my weaknesses. I can take on too many things at once and sometimes get overwhelmed. I also tend to procrastinate, which can make things stressful when deadlines pile up. Being a Peer Leader has forced me to manage my time

better and hold myself accountable, especially when students are counting on me. It's shown me that part of leadership is being aware of your limits and still showing up for others.

Overall, this semester taught me that leadership is not about perfection. It is about being genuine, committed to growth, and willing to learn from every experience. I am proud of the leader I have become, and I am excited to continue strengthening these skills as I move forward in my academic and professional journey.